from the Krishna.

Both Maharashtra and undivided Andhra Pradesh had then raised objections, which the tribunal addressed. Maharashtra was concerned about land submergence in its border districts; united Andhra, the lower riparian state, was worried over lower water flow downstream. A further report of KWDT-II came in November 2013. But a challenge is pending in the Supreme Court and the award has yet to be notified by the Centre. Karnataka's expansion plan is running smack into fresh opposition from the affected states, now including Telangana. Maharashtra has urged the Centre to halt Karnataka's move; chief minister Devendra Fadanavis promises a fresh challenge in the apex court. In Telangana, Bharat Rashtra Samithi working president K.T. Rama Rao echoed that, adding that the Revanth Reddy-led Congress government would be held responsible if it doesn't effectively thwart the state's potential loss of water legally.

Takeaways

- **Karnataka moves to execute 2010 tribunal order on dam height**
- **Maharashtra fears land submergence; Andhra, Telangana fret over low flow**
- **Legal challenge likely**

THREE-YEAR TIMELINE

The UKP Stage III is designed to irrigate up to 1.5 million acres of land in the drought-prone regions of northern Karnataka. "This is a big project. Farmers of the region will get water," Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah said at a press conference on September 16, after a special cabinet session to decide on compensation for land losers. This is a tricky issue that previous governments have wrestled with: of the envisaged total of 133,867 acres to be acquired, up to 75,563 acres would be submerged; 51,837 acres earmarked for canals; 6,467 acres for rehabilitation.

"Land prices are going up in the area. The previous government had fixed a compensation of Rs 24 lakh per acre for irrigated land and Rs 20 lakh per acre for arid land. But the farmers had not agreed, and so the government was unable to go ahead with it. We have decided to complete the acquisition in one phase," says deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, who also holds the water resources portfolio. The current government has offered a set of new rates: Rs 40 lakh per acre for irrigated land, Rs 30 lakh per acre for arid land, Rs 25 lakh per acre for land acquired for canals. "We want to complete the process in three fiscal years," says the CM.

Official estimates are that the project will also displace a total of 136,414 people, affecting 20 villages and some urban pockets. Currently, there are roughly 20,000 ongoing cases with regard to land acquisition which the government hopes to settle through arbitration under the Land Acquisition Act, 2013. To smooth out these issues, Shivakumar says a Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Compensation Authority will be set up, to be led by a judge.

In his telling, the award's notification was "postponed due to political pressures" from Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, and the Union water minister has promised a meeting soon. That one's unlikely to be too placid. ■

▶ UTTARAKHAND

Disaster Managing a Political Landslide

Old foes and rival factions reunited, the Uttarakhand Congress tries to turn over a new leaf for Polls 2027

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IN UTTARAKHAND, THE FOCUS THESE DAYS is firmly on matters of survival. Precisely such a spirit has taken hold of what's a natural disaster zone in its own right: the state Congress. Known more for fighting itself than the ruling BJP, old-timers have for long watched bemused as rival camps clashed in public, leaders undercut one another or jumped ship, and the party's vote base splintered. Into this landslide-prone zone comes a new script for soil consolidation. Of late, Congress leaders have begun exuding a more fraternal spirit: sharing podiums at panchayat meets, joining 'peace workshops', leading joint protests on issues as varied as vote *chori*, illegal mining, jobs and disaster relief.

REFORM FROM ABOVE

Sources date this attitudinal shift to June, when party brass Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi summoned state leaders to New Delhi. Old rivals were sat around the same table, roundly upbraided, and handed a blueprint for quake proofing. Not too soon. For, the assembly poll of 2027 isn't far.

The sharpest fault lines here ran between ex-CM Harish Rawat and former minister Harak Singh Rawat.